ISTQB CERTIFIED TESTER FOUNDATION LEVEL V4.0

9-Day Study Plan

A focused countdown from Saturday, October 17 to exam day. Daily sessions of three to four hours covering all six examinable chapters, chapter-by-chapter practice drills, two full mock exams and a final review - engineered around the official CTFL v4.0 question distribution.

Exam date: Monday, October 26, 2026

40 QUESTIONS · 60 MINUTES · PASS MARK 65%

The Exam at a Glance

The ISTQB Certified Tester Foundation Level (CTFL) v4.0 exam is a closed-book, multiple-choice examination administered by your local ISTQB Member Board or an accredited exam provider. The exam contains 40 questions and you are given 60 minutes to complete it. To pass, you must score at least 65 percent, which means 26 correct answers out of 40. Because you already work in testing, most of the terminology will feel familiar; your job over the next nine days is to replace informal habits with the exact vocabulary and distinctions the syllabus uses, because the questions test those distinctions precisely.

40	60	26/40	+15
multiple-choice questions	minutes, no break	needed to pass (65%)	extra minutes if English is not your first language

Every question is worth one point and there is no negative marking, so you must answer every single question even when you are unsure. Questions are written against learning objectives classified by cognitive level: K1 questions ask you to remember or recognize a term or concept, K2 questions ask you to understand and compare concepts, and K3 questions ask you to apply a technique in a short scenario. All six chapters are also examinable at K1 level, which means any keyword listed under a chapter heading can be tested directly. Most candidates fail by one or two points on K3-style items they rushed, so the plan in this document reserves dedicated practice time for those.

Where the 40 Questions Come From

The exam is not evenly weighted. Chapter 4, Test Analysis and Design, alone contributes roughly a third of all questions because it contains the practical techniques that define the Foundation Level. Chapters 1 and 2 together add another fifteen questions of conceptual material. The chart and table below reflect the official CTFL v4.0 question distribution, and your study time should follow the same proportions.

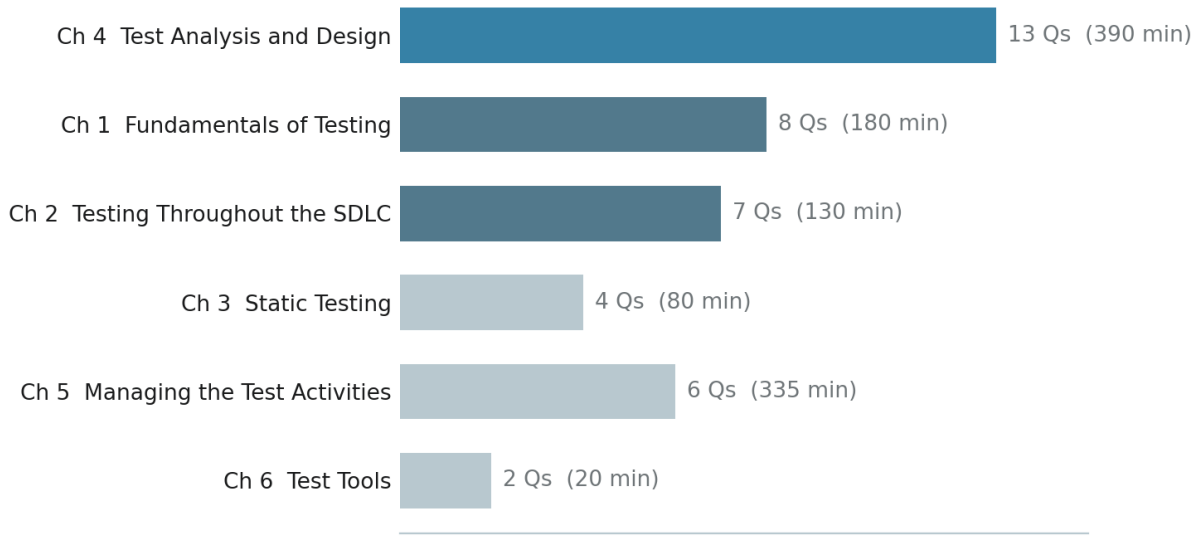


Figure 1: Official CTFL v4.0 exam question distribution and syllabus study time per chapter.

Ch.	Chapter	Study time	Qs	Exam focus
1	Fundamentals of Testing	180 min	8	Principles, test process, testware, roles
2	Testing Throughout the SDLC	130 min	7	Test levels, test types, shift-left, DevOps
3	Static Testing	80 min	4	Reviews, review roles, static analysis
4	Test Analysis and Design	390 min	13	EP, BVA, decision tables, state transition, coverage, collaboration
5	Managing the Test Activities	335 min	6	Planning, estimation, risks, quadrants, defect reports
6	Test Tools	20 min	2	Tool types, automation benefits and risks

Table 1: Chapter weights used to build the nine-day plan.

The Nine-Day Countdown

Each study day below is built from three to four focused hours. A typical day has one reading block using Document 2 (Complete Study Notes), one drill block using Document 3 (Question Bank), and one short review block using the keyword lists and Document 4 (Cheat Sheet). Work with the notes open, but always close them before answering the drill questions so that recall, not recognition, is what you train. The two weekend days at the end are reserved for full timed simulations, which are the single best predictor of your readiness.

Day 1 - Saturday, October 17: Fundamentals of Testing (Chapter 1)

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (90 m)	Read notes Ch.1: what testing is, why it is necessary, the seven principles	Write the seven principles from memory; check wording against the notes
Block 2 (60 m)	Test process activities, testware, traceability, testing roles vs. development roles	Draw the seven test activities and name one work product for each
Block 3 (60 m)	Drill: 12 chapter-1 questions (Document 3) + keyword box review	Log every wrong answer in your error notebook with the reason you missed it

Day 2 - Sunday, October 18: Testing Throughout the SDLC (Chapter 2)

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (80 m)	SDLC impact on testing, good practices, TDD/ATDD/BDD, DevOps, shift-left	List the five shift-left practices and the benefits of DevOps from memory
Block 2 (80 m)	The five test levels and four test types; confirmation vs. regression testing; maintenance triggers	Reproduce the levels/types table and write the difference between confirmation and regression in one sentence each
Block 3 (60 m)	Drill: 12 chapter-2 questions + 5-minute keyword review of Chapter 1	Error notebook update; re-answer yesterday's misses without notes

Day 3 - Monday, October 19: Static Testing (Chapter 3)

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (70 m)	Static vs. dynamic testing, work products examinable statically, value of static testing	List seven defect types cheaper to find statically (requirements, design, code, standards, interfaces, security, coverage)
Block 2 (70 m)	Review process: five activities, six roles, four review types, success factors	Build the review-type ladder: informal, walkthrough, technical review, inspection
Block 3 (60 m)	Drill: 12 chapter-3 questions + mixed recap of chapters 1-2 keywords	Error notebook update; note which review role does what

Day 4 - Tuesday, October 20: Black-Box Techniques (Chapter 4, part 1)

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (100 m)	Equivalence partitioning and boundary value analysis (2-value and 3-value)	Take a 1-100 age field and write partitions plus all 2-value and 3-value boundary tests
Block 2 (80 m)	Decision table testing and state transition testing (all states, valid transitions, all transitions)	Build one decision table from a 3-condition rule and one state table for a PIN entry example
Block 3 (40 m)	Redo your accumulated error notebook so far	Nothing new: pure consolidation before the hardest day

Day 5 - Wednesday, October 21: White-Box, Experience-Based and Collaboration (Chapter 4, part 2)

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (70 m)	Statement vs. branch coverage, subsumption, value of white-box testing	Given a two-branch code sketch, compute statement and branch coverage percentages
Block 2 (70 m)	Error guessing and fault attacks, exploratory and session-based testing, checklist-based testing	Write the definition differences: error guessing vs. exploratory vs. checklist-based
Block 3 (80 m)	User stories (3 Cs, INVEST), acceptance criteria formats, ATDD; drill: all 12 chapter-4 questions	Score at least 10/12 on the chapter-4 drill; else schedule 30 extra minutes on Day 8

Day 6 - Thursday, October 22: Managing the Test Activities (Chapter 5, part 1)

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (80 m)	Test plan purpose and content, tester contribution to iteration/release planning, entry vs. exit criteria	Write typical entry criteria and exit criteria lists from memory
Block 2 (80 m)	Estimation techniques (ratios, extrapolation, Wideband Delphi, three-point) and test case prioritization strategies	Solve three three-point estimation exercises: $E = (a + 4m + b) / 6$, $SD = (b - a) / 6$
Block 3 (60 m)	Test pyramid and testing quadrants; draw both models	Place each quadrant's example tests and check against the notes

Day 7 - Friday, October 23: Risks, Monitoring, Configuration, Defects (Ch. 5 part 2 + Ch. 6)

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (80 m)	Risk level = likelihood x impact; project vs. product risks; risk analysis and control; mitigation by testing	Classify ten mixed risks as project or product and justify each
Block 2 (70 m)	Metrics, test progress vs. test completion reports, configuration management, defect report fields; Chapter 6 tool types and automation benefits/risks	Write the defect report field list from memory; summarize two benefits and two risks of automation
Block 3 (60 m)	Drill: 12 chapter-5 questions + 12 chapter-6 questions	Error notebook update; flag any quadrant/estimation repeats

Day 8 - Saturday, October 24: Mock Exam 1 + repair

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (60 m)	Mock Exam 1 under strict exam conditions: 40 questions, 60 minutes, no notes	Score it with the answer key; you want 30 or more correct
Block 2 (90 m)	Review every wrong and every guessed answer; classify each miss as vocabulary, distinction, or calculation	Rewrite the syllabus sentence that answers each missed question
Block 3 (60 m)	Revisit your two weakest chapters using the notes and their keyword boxes	Re-solve all error notebook items from Days 1-7

Day 9 - Sunday, October 25: Mock Exam 2 + final review

Block	Focus	Concrete output
Block 1 (60 m)	Mock Exam 2 under exam conditions; simulate the same start time as your real exam if possible	Score it; you want 32 or more correct
Block 2 (60 m)	Review misses, then one full pass over Document 4 (Cheat Sheet) out loud	Confirm you can state all seven principles, five levels, four types, four review types
Block 3 (45 m)	Light keyword box pass over all chapters; stop early, eat, walk, sleep early	No new material after this block - sleep is scoring points tomorrow

How to Study Each Day

Active recall beats re-reading. When you finish a section, close the notes and write down what you remember, then check and repair. The syllabus is vocabulary-dense, so the keyword boxes at the start of every chapter in Document 2 are your fastest review tool: any term you cannot explain in one sentence goes into your error notebook. Keep the error notebook from day one; re-solving your own past mistakes is the highest-yield activity in the last three days, more than reading anything new.

- Read a section, close the notes, and write what you remember - then verify.
- Answer drill questions with notes closed; mark guesses as wrong even if correct.
- For every miss, record: the topic, why the right answer is right, and why your answer was tempting.
- End every session with a five-minute keyword pass of one earlier chapter (spaced repetition).

Mock Exam Protocol and Scoring

Sit both mocks exactly as the real event: 60 minutes on the clock, no phone, no notes, no pauses. Budget ninety seconds per question on the first pass, flag anything slower, and return with the remaining time. Grade strictly with the key, then compute your score: 26 correct is the pass line, 30 or more is comfortable, 32 or more is target on the second mock. If Mock 1 lands below 30, spend Day 8 entirely on your two weakest chapters and push one mock to the morning of Day 9.

In the real exam, read the last line of the stem first - many questions end with NOT, EXCEPT, or BEST, and half of the traps live there. For K3 items, write the tiny computation in the margin: boundary values, coverage fractions, $E = (a + 4m + b) / 6$. Never leave a question blank, and never change an answer unless you can quote the syllabus reason; first instincts backed by preparation are usually right.

Exam-Day Checklist - Monday, October 26

The last twenty-four hours are about logistics and calm, not content. Prepare the administrative details the evening before so that nothing cognitive is wasted on the morning. If your exam is online, test the platform and your connection at least two hours before the slot; if it is at a test center, plan to arrive thirty minutes early.

- Confirm start time, venue or exam link, and required ID the night before.
- Bring (or have ready) the registration confirmation and one government-issued photo ID.
- Eat a normal meal before the exam; avoid heavy caffeine you do not usually drink.
- Arrive / log in 30 minutes early to complete check-in without stress.
- During the exam: two passes - answer the easy 80%, flag the rest, return and fill every blank.
- Track time at question 20: you should be at or before the 30-minute mark.

> **You are ready when the drills say so**
>
> You have nine days, a working tester's intuition, and a plan that matches the exam blueprint exactly. Follow the blocks, trust the drills, and walk in on Monday expecting to pass - because 26 out of 40 is a bar this plan clears with room to spare.